

CROSS-CUTTING · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam Technique and Qualifier Words

Reading the question, managing the clock, and eliminating well.

COVERS EXAM SKILLS SCENARIOS 6 MODULE 17 of 22

The qualifier is the question. Everything above it just describes the situation.

What the qualifiers actually mean

QUALIFIER	WHAT THE CORRECT ANSWER WILL LOOK LIKE
MOST cost-effective	Cheapest option that still meets every stated requirement
LEAST operational overhead	Managed or serverless. Custom code is almost never right
MOST secure	Least privilege, no long-lived credentials, nothing public
MOST highly available	Across AZs first. Multi-Region only if the question demands it
MOST performant	Ignore cost. Choose the fastest option that meets requirements
MINIMAL downtime	Replication and cutover, never dump and restore
FEWEST changes to the application	Managed equivalents and drop-in replacements, not rewrites

ON THE EXAM

Two options can both work. The qualifier is what makes one of them wrong.

How to read a question

01

Read the last line

Find the qualifier and the actual ask before anything else.

02

Scan for numbers

RTO, RPO, runtimes, data volumes, bandwidth. These eliminate mechanically.

03

Find the constraint

The sentence saying what must not change, or what is not a concern.

04

Eliminate two

Usually two options fail a stated requirement outright.

05

Apply the qualifier

Of the two survivors, the qualifier decides.

ON THE EXAM

If both remaining options still look right, you have missed a constraint. Go back and find it rather than guessing.

Distractor shapes worth recognising

- ◆ **The invented restriction.** X cannot be used with Y. If you have never read that limitation, be suspicious.
- ◆ **The right idea, wrong scope.** A real mechanism applied at the account level when the question needs it per principal.
- ◆ **The over-engineered answer.** Multi-Region when multi-AZ was asked for. Correct, and marked wrong.
- ◆ **The detective answer to a preventive question.** Config detects; SCPs prevent. Read for 'never' and 'must not'.
- ◆ **The custom code answer.** 'Write a Lambda function that polls...' under a LEAST overhead qualifier.

ON THE EXAM

The best distractor is one that genuinely works but is wrong for a stated reason. Find the stated reason.

Managing one hundred and thirty minutes

- ◆ **Two minutes per question** is the budget. Most take less, which builds reserve for the hard ones.
- ◆ **Answer everything as you go.** There is no penalty for a wrong answer, so never leave a blank.
- ◆ **Flag and move on** at ninety seconds if you are stuck. A flagged question with an answer is safe.
- ◆ **Aim to finish the first pass in about a hundred minutes**, leaving thirty for flagged questions.
- ◆ **Do not change answers** on review without a specific reason you can articulate.

ON THE EXAM

Fifteen of the sixty-five questions are unscored trials. A question that feels unreasonably obscure may simply not count.

A company needs to process uploaded documents. Each document takes about thirty seconds to process. Volume is around two hundred documents per day, arriving unpredictably during business hours.

The team has one developer and no operations staff.

Which solution requires the LEAST operational overhead?

- A An EC2 instance running a polling script, managed by an Auto Scaling group
- B S3 event notifications triggering a Lambda function
- C An ECS service on EC2 processing from an SQS queue
- D A cron job on an EC2 instance checking the bucket every minute

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which solution requires the LEAST operational overhead?

- A

 EC2 with polling script
An instance to patch, a script to maintain, and an Auto Scaling group to configure, for two hundred short tasks a day.
- B

 S3 events to Lambda
No servers, no polling, no scaling configuration. Thirty seconds is well inside the limit and the trigger is native.
- C

 ECS on EC2 with SQS
Removes some work but keeps the cluster hosts, and adds a queue that the native S3 trigger makes unnecessary.
- D

 Cron on EC2
The most manual option, with an always-running instance and up to a minute of latency per document.

THE SIGNAL

Under a LEAST operational overhead qualifier, count what the team has to maintain. Lowest count wins.

The same document processing workload as before, at the same volume, but each document now takes forty minutes to process because a new machine learning step has been added.

The team is unchanged: one developer, no operations staff.

Which solution requires the LEAST operational overhead?

- A S3 event notifications triggering a Lambda function
- B S3 events triggering an AWS Batch job on Fargate
- C An EC2 Auto Scaling group polling an SQS queue
- D Chained Lambda functions checkpointing progress to DynamoDB

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which solution requires the LEAST operational overhead?

- A

 Lambda
*Forty minutes exceeds the fifteen-minute maximum.
Correct in the previous question, impossible in this one.*
- B

 Batch on Fargate
No servers to manage, no runtime limit, and it provisions and terminates compute automatically for each job.
- C

 EC2 Auto Scaling with SQS
Works, but hands instances to a team with no operations staff.
- D

 Chained Lambdas with checkpointing
Substantial bespoke complexity built to work around a limit that Batch and Fargate do not have.

THE SIGNAL

One number changed and the answer changed. Always check runtime against the fifteen-minute limit before choosing Lambda.

A company must ensure that no engineer in any of its thirty accounts can disable CloudTrail logging. Several accounts have local administrators.

The security team is currently alerted when logging stops and re-enables it manually.

Which solution meets the requirement?

- ☐ A An AWS Config rule that detects disabled trails and triggers remediation
- ☐ B A service control policy denying the CloudTrail stop and delete actions
- ☐ C An IAM policy attached to all engineers denying those actions
- ☐ D A CloudWatch alarm on the CloudTrail stop event notifying the security team

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which solution meets the requirement?

- A

 Config rule with remediation
*Detective. Logging stops, then resumes, leaving a gap.
'Cannot disable' is not satisfied by re-enabling afterwards.*
- B

 SCP denying the actions
Preventive, and it sits above account administrators so it cannot be removed locally. The call fails outright.
- C

 IAM policy on engineers
Right idea, wrong scope. A local administrator can detach it, and it must be maintained in thirty accounts.
- D

 CloudWatch alarm
Notification only. It automates the current process rather than preventing the action.

THE SIGNAL

'Cannot' and 'must never' mean preventive. Detection and remediation answer a different question.

A stateless application currently runs on twelve On-Demand instances at steady load, twenty-four hours a day, with occasional short peaks handled by Auto Scaling.

The company plans to keep this architecture for at least three years and wants the MOST cost-effective arrangement.

What should the solutions architect recommend?

- ☐ A Move all twelve instances to Spot
- ☐ B Cover the twelve baseline instances with a three-year Savings Plan and use Spot for peaks
- ☐ C Keep everything On-Demand and rely on Auto Scaling
- ☐ D Purchase three-year Reserved Instances for peak capacity

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect recommend?

- A

 All twelve on Spot
Cheapest per hour and risks the entire baseline disappearing if the Spot pool is reclaimed.
- B

 Savings Plan baseline, Spot peaks
The steady twelve get the maximum commitment discount over three years, and the stateless peaks run at Spot prices.
- C

 All On-Demand
Takes no discount at all on twelve instances running every hour for three years.
- D

 Reserve peak capacity
Pays continuously for capacity used occasionally. Reserve the baseline, never the peak.

THE SIGNAL

Steady baseline plus variable peak plus a three-year horizon is the blended answer.
Reserve the floor, never the ceiling.

A team proposes migrating a monolithic application to microservices across three Regions with active-active DynamoDB global tables, in order to fix intermittent slowness reported by users in one office.

Investigation shows the slowness correlates with a single overloaded reporting query running every fifteen minutes against the primary database.

What should the solutions architect recommend?

- ☐ A Proceed with the multi-Region microservices migration
- ☐ B Move the reporting query to a read replica and reassess
- ☐ C Add a second Region for the office reporting slowness
- ☐ D Increase the primary database instance size by four times

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect recommend?

- A

 Proceed with the migration
An enormous programme of work aimed at a problem the investigation has already traced to one query.
- B

 Move the query to a read replica
Matches the remedy to the diagnosed cause, at minimal cost and risk. Reassess afterwards with real evidence.
- C

 Add a Region
Distance is not the cause. A second Region does nothing about a query overloading the primary every fifteen minutes.
- D

 Four times the instance size
Buys headroom to absorb a badly-placed query permanently, at permanent cost, without addressing it.

THE SIGNAL

The exam does include 'do not build the impressive thing' answers. Match the remedy to the diagnosed cause.

You are ninety minutes into the exam with twenty questions remaining and eight already flagged. The current question describes an unfamiliar combination of services and you have narrowed it to two plausible options after about a minute.

Neither option obviously violates a stated requirement.

What is the best course of action?

- ☐ A Keep working on it until you are confident, since accuracy matters more than speed
- ☐ B Reread the final sentence for the qualifier, choose the better fit, flag it, and move on
- ☐ C Leave it blank and return at the end with more information
- ☐ D Pick randomly between the two and do not flag it

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best course of action?

- A

 Keep working until confident
Forty minutes for twenty questions is already tight. Spending five here risks rushing several later ones.
- B

 Qualifier, answer, flag, move on
The qualifier is the most likely thing to separate two plausible options, and an answered flagged question can score while you move on.
- C

 Leave it blank
A blank scores zero for certain. There is no penalty for guessing, so an answer is always better than none.
- D

 Guess without flagging
The guess is fine; not flagging means you cannot find it again if time allows.

THE SIGNAL

Twenty questions in forty minutes is two minutes each with no slack. Answer, flag, move.

Module 14 takeaways

- ◆ **Read the qualifier first.** It is the criterion the answer is judged against.
- ◆ **Numbers eliminate mechanically.** Runtimes, RPO, bandwidth, volumes. Check them before judging.
- ◆ **Find the sentence that exists to eliminate an option.** Nearly every question has one.
- ◆ **'Cannot' and 'must never' mean preventive,** not detective.
- ◆ **Answer, flag, move on.** Never leave a blank.

ON THE EXAM

Four practice exams follow. Sit the first one now, then return to whichever domain your misses cluster in.